

Project Future Case

Kelley School – Indiana University

NOTE: This case description is very loosely based on the Project Hope initiative implemented by the MSIS program in summer 2020. People and processes used here do not represent what actually took place in the execution of Project Hope. Those references are for illustration only.

Bikar Prabapin is the chair of the MS in Information Systems Program (the “Program”) in a prestigious Midwestern Business School (the “School”). As a global pandemic is poised to disrupt many small business and NGOs, these organizations need to transition to online-based operations. To help in this endeavor, teams of students volunteered to support the transition. The organizations will gain much needed help while students will get experience working on technology-based consulting projects. This effort has been named “**Project Future**”.

Bikar Prabapin wants to make the process of accepting clients, assigning teams, and delivering results to the client organizations as streamlined as possible. A team of volunteer consultants and developers will help by modeling the processes (and eventually creating prototypes) related to Project Future. Angela Hodge, Stan Godfrey, and Kim Kelley are alums of the Program and eager to help Bikar in this task.

Bikar: Hello, folks! It is wonderful to have you helping with this project. The student teams have a lot of work ahead of them and making our processes as simple and precise as possible will be a big help.

Kim: Of course, Bikar! It is great to be able to help.

Stan: We owe a lot to the Program so you can count on us to support this initiative.

Angela: Absolutely. To start, Bikar, could you tell us the overall organizational structure that we are dealing with?

Bikar: Sure. Prof. Adam Dennison, who is also the president of a very important IS professional organization, and I are the people in charge of the overall initiative. We have recruited a group of faculty to serve as advisors but they will not have any direct contact with the system, so we would not need to include them. Their contact with students would be completely ad-hoc.

Stan: Sounds good.

Bikar: Then we have two major student committees, formed by a mix of alums and senior Program students. The first committee is our management committee, or “MC”. I have hand-picked those people and they have the most important tasks in the project, since they manage the teams and the project application process.

Angela: Great. So, what about the second committee?

Bikar: That's the technical committee, or "TC". They will advise on the viability of the solution proposed by the teams. We want to make sure that whatever is proposed by the teams is actually feasible. They also work as technical advisors for the teams on an ad-hoc basis. Again, this is a team that was hand-picked due to their expertise. The projects should be relatively simple, but we want to make sure that everything that is recommended can be implemented.

Kim: Great! Anybody else who is involved?

Bikar: No. We want to make sure that this is as lean as possible, without much bureaucracy.

Angela: So, you said that the faculty advisors would not have an interaction with the system. What about you?

Bikar: I do not want to have any role managing the projects directly. I will obviously keep tabs on how things are going because we want to make sure we deliver value to our clients, while giving a good experience to our students and enhancing the reputation of the Program and the School. I will be a super-user of any system that is built to support Project Future, with the ability to check and assess any system functionality, but I will not be directly involved with any process.

Stan: Sounds good. We can certainly make it happen. Perhaps now it would be a good time for you to start explaining the processes involved in Project Future.

Bikar: Sure thing. First, we would like to have an application portal to capture new clients and projects, where clients could apply to have a team working with them.

Kim: Perfect. Can a client have more than one project?

Bikar: That's a great question. We do not expect to have more than one project per client each year, but over time, if Project Future remains active, which I certainly hope to be the case, we could have clients with multiple projects. So, yes, a client can have multiple projects over the years.

Angela: That means that we need to have different records for clients and projects.

Stan: Exactly. Bikar, can a client be rejected? Or everyone applying will get a team?

Bikar: Clients aren't rejected but we might reject a project. We do not expect to have an unlimited number of students and some projects might not be a good fit because of the topic or the size. So, once a client applies with a project, a member of the MC will get in touch with the client for an interview to gain more details.

Kim: Would you like us to keep track of the process of scheduling interviews?

Bikar: That would not be necessary, because those might be informal, via email, Zoom, or whatever other means. However, we would need to keep track of the outcomes of the interviews, so that the member of the MC who interviewed the client can add his/her assessment of the project.

Kim: Lots of responsibility for the MC members, then.

Bikar: That's the reason they are handpicked!

Angela: So, who should make the decisions about which projects will be accepted?

Bikar: The MC, after the interview notes are captured for all the proposed projects. At that point, they will know more about every project. They will also know how many students we will have available to work on the projects and they can make their allocations.

Kim: Do you have a particular formula for the number of people in each team?

Bikar: We will usually have four to five people working on each project but that is variable. In general, we will try to accommodate as many projects and as many students as we can.

Stan: So, there is no formula.

Bikar: No, we will rely on the judgment of the MC. They will consult informally with me regarding the number of student and project applications and we will try to have a good match. We don't know how many students and projects we will have each year, so it is hard to come up with a hard number. So, the decision will be something like "it seems we can have about 240 students working on about 60 projects."

Kim: Perfect. Perhaps we can talk about the student recruitment later but let's concentrate on the project approval process now. You said that the MC makes the call about which projects to accept.

Bikar: Yes, they will go over each project's details, including interview notes, and for each of them they will say "YES" or "NO". Those that receive a "NO" should immediately receive a kind message thanking them for the application but explaining that there is only a limited number of projects that can be accepted.

Angela: What about the projects that are accepted?

Bikar: Those clients should automatically receive a note with an attachment containing a legal document authorizing students of the Program to work on their projects. They will have a two-week period to submit the signed document back into the system.

Angela: And if they don't?

Bikar: They always send it back because they really want the free consulting services. This is more of a formality at this point. We just need a way for the system to accept the document.

Stan: Sounds good then. So, at the end of these steps, we would have a group of projects that would be ready for the allocation of student teams. Perhaps it is time now to talk about how students are recruited?

Bikar: Perfect. To be honest, we should go beyond our current students. I think we should invite alums and incoming students to participate.

Angela: That's interesting. Should we just have an open invitation and a site where people could apply?

Bikar: I think we can do better than that. We have our alumni database and we could select those who have graduated in the last three years so that we do not go too far back and invite more senior people who might not have the time or the availability to do that. Then we have the list of our current students and the list of incoming students, all the way to sophomores. We should use these lists to send invitations so that they can apply in the web site. I do not think we should model and develop this part, though. We can take of that outside the new system, with a simple mail merge.

Kim: From what I'm hearing, we don't need to bring those lists into this new system because you team will contact those people in some way outside of this system?

Bikar: **Correct.**

Kim: Would everybody who applied be guaranteed a spot to help. It would be hard to say "No" to people trying to help.

Bikar: True, it would be hard, but the MC will have to go over each application, which should include a resume and application letter, and make some decisions. I do not want to end up with small projects where we have seven people allocated to do the work that four people could easily do. The experience would not be a good one for anyone involved. I think that with the right "rejection" message we can avoid hurting people who volunteered to help.

Angela: So, the MC would check every single application and then decide who is in and who is out.

Bikar: Exactly. Remember that this will go somewhat in parallel with the project application process so the MC will have a good idea about how many people will be needed. I do not think we should have a rigid limit regarding the amount of people we accept. I will be in constant informal communication with the MC and we can figure out what the best number of students would be and which criteria we should use. We would probably accept more people than actually needed in case someone has to pull off and we can always have a couple of teams with some extra people.

Kim: So, everybody in the list of applicants would receive one of two outcomes, "YES" or "NO", correct? I assume you would want a message to be automatically sent to each applicant either way.

Bikar: Exactly. Once that is done, we can start allocating students to the teams that are responsible for the projects.

Stan: I was going to ask about that. Who is in charge of that? The hardworking MC?

Bikar: Yes. They will go over each accepted student and then allocate them to a team. Each team is responsible for a project and each team will also have a "Team Leader" selected by the MC. Those would usually be one of the alums or a current MSIS student.

Angela: Would they be notified once the selections are done?

Bikar: Yes. I would like the system to conclude the team selection and allocation process by sending a message to each team member and to each client about the team allocation, including a suggestion about the next steps.

Kim: You said before that maybe some people might have to pull off from the project. Should the system manage that?

Bikar: I do not think that would be necessary. Again, we would usually have teams with more people than needed to complete the project anyway. If something really strange happens, we can always make some ad-hoc manual adjustments. You do not need to be concerned with that.

Stan: So, at that point the teams are “released in the wild” to work with the clients, correct? Do we care about how they do the work?

Bikar: Absolutely. We have the reputation of the Program and the School to protect AND we want to make sure the clients get good outcomes from the project. This is where the Technical Committee, the “TC”, plays a role.

Kim: I almost forgot about them...

Bikar: So, the teams are responsible for three deliverables: the project charter, a final report, and a final presentation. I would obviously expect the project charter to come first, but I do not want to impose any deadline because each project might be different. We can always monitor behind the scenes which teams have not submitted their project charter by a certain date.

Angela: OK, so what is the role of the TC here?

Bikar: Every time one of these documents is submitted, the TC should be notified and receive a copy of the document. After the TC reviews the document, they would provide feedback in the system about any changes that are needed. At that point, the team should submit a final version after considering the feedback, even if the feedback says everything is fine.

Stan: Would the system need to inform the TC if a new version has been submitted?

Bikar: Yes, that would be good, but for the final versions, a copy would not need to be sent.

Angela: So, I am assuming that when the team submits their final version of the presentation and report, that indicates the project is complete.

Bikar: Exactly. At that point, I would like to have the system notifying the client and requesting their assessment about the project.

Kim: So that the client can provide feedback about the experience?

Bikar: Exactly. We can ask several questions that allows them to rank parts of the experience and also have a place when they can provide comments. The feedback can be used to promote the Program and the School, assuming that the experience is positive. I also would like the team to receive a copy of the feedback. That will be an important learning outcome.

Stan: I am pretty sure the experience will be positive for the vast majority of projects. We have some great students at the School and in the Program. We know that based on our own experience.

Bikar: Your work here is the living proof of the amazing students who graduate from the Program. Your help is really appreciated!

Angela: We are happy to help. We will get back to you with our models soon.

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Note: Model every process you identify in this dialogue except when explicitly mentioned that you should not (for example, when an informal communication takes place outside the system). Follow the case as precisely as possible but feel free to complement any missing information with your own assumptions, as long as they are reasonable.